

Look at me!

Architecture has always had its icons. For centuries they took the form of churches and temples. In our secular age we still need familiar and reassuring reference points - but in the rush to fill this void, designers have been falling over themselves to apply the iconic treatment to every conceivable building. These new designs have names like Spiral, Cocoon, Cloud or Vortex, inspiring a sense of poetic wonder. Often, though, they are just ordinary buildings distorted into unnecessarily complicated shapes. Their main purpose is to attract our attention.

The true architectural icon is a building that is unmistakable, often provocative, and carries cultural signals far beyond its purpose. Obvious iconic landmarks include the Sydney opera house, the Pompidou centre, even the new Scottish parliament building - all of which initially met with disapproval. These modern icons simultaneously signal their function and their public importance. They convey the spirit of their age; they are both useful and memorable.

But there are also less significant buildings that aspire to iconic status but do not always deserve the profile their sponsors demand. In this context, the Guggenheim museum in Bilbao has had a significant effect. I am not convinced it is a great work of architecture, although its public credentials are clear. Its significance as a building is

less in its extraordinary shape and surface (which many now consider formulaic) than in the popularity of its formal abstraction.

This is an important building that gives little obvious indication of its content. While we are all now attuned to identifying such structures as cultural institutions, could this abstract formula be applied to more prosaic buildings - a hospital or a school perhaps?

With Bilbao, "celebrity architecture", in all its low-cut and high-rise disguises, came of age. It was certain to be followed by a torrent of imitators - and indeed, the launch of the Guggenheim coincided with a new public appetite for bling-bling architecture. Lottery investment and the subsequent press interest provoked a demand for "finished" images. This has encouraged the presentation of a single uncomplicated idea, an architectural one-liner that once in the public realm would be difficult to change.

As competition increases, each image has to be more extraordinary and shocking in order to eclipse the last. Each new design has to be instantly memorable - more iconic. This one-upmanship was, and is, a fatuous and self-indulgent game.

You need only take a trip down the Thames from Southwark to Wandsworth to see the effects. On what I now call the Costa del Icon, you see an array of second-rate structures, all shrilly demanding attention, without

any relationship to each other. Sophisticated computer imagery and carefully lit models mean the original plans are very seductive, but their concrete realisation often leaves us disappointed and suspicious. Not only that, but the impact of these celebrity misfits is diminished by their ubiquity. How many landmarks does one city need?

Perhaps we should ask some simple questions before handing out more money and plaudits to "visionary" designers. What is the value of turning functional buildings into iconic ones? Are we simply trying too hard? Is a building's purpose compromised by its style? And what contribution does the icon make to its surroundings?

Too many iconic buildings and the fabric of the city is distorted, but too few and the city is dull. It is the quiet strength of ordinary streets and unexceptional buildings that allows the icon to be special. We need to look at the city as a whole, and no building should leave it worse off.

Although we talk of the "Bilbao effect" - how one remarkable building can change the way in which a city is perceived and boost its economy - there is little evidence to suggest that architecture in the form of a single gesture can really have such restorative powers. Without easyJet, it is far from certain that the small economic gains in Bilbao would be measurable at all. But now every failing town or institution is considering some sort of architectural makeover. A smart new building can have the opposite effect of showing up those areas that are

struggling.

At the London Metropolitan University, Daniel Libeskind has tried to work his magic on Holloway Road. The new graduate centre, called - typically - Orion, and formed from three intersecting shards of grey metal, is a further development of the crumpled thinking seen in his plans for the Victoria and Albert museum's Spiral extension. Despite the elaborate explanations of the concept on his website, the design is little more than a cultural placebo, a distraction from the university's long-term management issues that might do more harm than good.

The office building, meanwhile, is the true chameleon of our time. We have seen it mutate from a Miesian ideal into a postmodern palace, into a hi-tech machine, into organic forms and now blobs dressed up as art (such as Will Alsop's Cloud in Liverpool). Strangely, for buildings intended to inspire efficiency, these cosmetic changes are rarely market- or customer-led. They are more often than not driven simply by the need to get planning approval. We saw this at London Bridge, where the planning inspector hailed Renzo Piano's assembly of glass shards as an artistic success. It has now, predictably, been followed by the proposal for Elizabeth House at Waterloo. This domineering, elephantine project is made entirely of glass and is claimed to reflect light in a way that is varied and beautiful. Enormous it is; beautiful it is not.

Its formidable design team, which includes an artist, is at

pains to persuade us that this is an object of cultural merit. But the designers were simply following the lead of some other, perhaps better regarded, icons where the building's exterior is similarly and abstractly packaged as art.

So what are the iconic designs that get it right? Well, there are four that deserve to be mentioned and celebrated. Will Alsop's unusual plans for Goldsmiths college, which work well in the urban fabric of New Cross, south London.

Richard Rogers's proposed tower in Leadenhall Street, the city of London - although taller than Swiss Re, it develops into a thin vertical wedge that brilliantly defers to St Paul's. The London Eye, whose sheer scale and directional quality make it a delightful addition to the city. And Herzog and de Meuron's recent prizewinning scheme for a new cultural centre in Jerez, the city of flamenco, which avoids the complicated and contorted geometries of their rivals.

All these projects prove that it is possible to create buildings that are at once visually impressive, workable and in keeping with their surroundings without compromising architectural integrity. These are true icons.

- This is an edited extract from Graham Morrison's speech to the Architects' Journal/Bovis Awards for Architecture dinner.